

bomb to buy it. Oracle, MySQL are other database applications which should be considered if your database will eventually run into thousands of records. For a small office, Access would be more than enough to get the work done.

Security

Each computer on your business network should be properly secured against viruses, worms, Trojans and malicious spywares. The general trend is to install a copy of an Anti-virus on each machine, and further bolster it by having personal firewalls and spyware removal tools running in the background. Well, that's passé; I will suggest a better way.

It's not enough to have an Anti-virus running on all PCs, as they need to be periodically updated with recent virus signatures. Most people often forget to do so, or the update fails due to numerous reasons. Instead of opting for individual anti-virus licenses, you should consider deploying an anti-virus server. In such a system, the anti-virus is running on a server and its client runs on individual machines. The advantage is better manageability, higher efficiency and total control. Only the anti-virus server connects to the Internet and gets the new virus signatures, and then it automatically updates all the client machines without human intervention. This not only saves time and effort, but also minimises the use of Internet bandwidth, since the signature file is downloaded just once. The anti-virus server should be hosted on proper server hardware though, or at least on a powerful PC to ensure smooth operation.

In terms of manageability, a system administrator can check the status of each client from his desk, and can mend problems without getting up from his seat. He can also force check any machine on the network for viruses and other malicious content, thus ensuring a virus free network. Anti-virus applications are more affordable these days, and they are a must if you're ever going to protect your data—so make sure to budget for them. You will easily earn back the investment in terms of man hours by keeping your network virus-free.

installing a firewall on or between the gateway and your network, spyware problems can be tackled. This, in conjunction with a proper proxy server will save you a lot of headaches in the long run.

There are many types of firewalls available, individual machines can have personal firewalls, and some examples are ZoneAlarm, Comodo, etc., but these are not as effective as network level firewalls. An old Linux box (PC) with correctly configured IP Tables can be turned into an excellent network firewall. Proprietary hardware firewall devices are also

available, but they are expensive, and you have a large network, these can be ignored.

Network

The Internet plays a pivotal role in all offices today, and as a resource, it needs to be shared amongst all computers on the network. A decent speed Internet connection won't come cheap, and hence every effort has to be made to ensure as a resource it is properly shared and utilised. Setting up a proxy server is the best way to do this. Linux can be put to good use here, as one of the best proxy servers, Squid, is available for free. Squid is an excellent proxy server, and to be effective, it needs to be configured properly. Also, it is a caching proxy server, so you should pay attention to utilising and exploiting this to its maximum. Though Squid is deployed by many, the caching part is often left out, which is not advisable. Implement it properly, and you will tell the difference in terms of Internet speeds. On the hardware front, even an old machine will do. So long as you upgrade the RAM and put in a new hard disk, there's not much that can go wrong here.

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In all probability, have at least one Linux machine on your network running. This machine can be used to administrate the proxy server, file server, and firewall, or it can also be used to diagnose network related problems. Get a good network analyser such as WireShark (formerly Ethereal) to detect network problems. Such a machine can also be used for remote administration of Servers, FTP transfers, etc.

I hope this guide helps you to grasp the basics involved in selecting the right kind of software for your small organisation. If you have any suggestions, queries, questions or need any help, drop us a mail and I will be glad to listen and help you. ☐

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